kind of exposure at the college that helped mature his intellectual transformation. He was tutored by those who disagreed with Gandhian non-violence and favoured instead a violent revolutionary overthrow of imperialism. This was against the background of mounting anti-government feelings in Punjab. Though his academic prowess was great, Bhagat Singh failed to graduate despite having passed his BA intermediate examinations in 1923. It was not because he spent too much time on sports. In fact, he abjured these. He was good in drama classes. He even played an active part in the college drama club. Indeed, he became an accomplished actor in the National College. His fame spread widely in other colleges as well for his acting skills. He liked singing and was good at that too. Remarkably, he cared little for his appearance. This was remembered decades later by those who knew him at the National College, where he was known to enter the class-room with his unkempt hair loosely tied underneath a crumpled pagri (turban). He is remembered as having worn ‘Khaddar’ clothes, of home-spun cotton. These were often unclean and ill-fitted. While the custom among young men in those days was to wear a pair of loose trousers tied by a drawstring around the waist, Bhagat Singh instead wore a lungi, which is an even looser garment that is similar to a sarong and which extended all the way down to his ankles. [14]

His fellow revolutionary, Ajoy Ghosh, remembers the sixteen-year-old in 1923 as ‘tall and thin, rather shabbily dressed, very quiet’, but surprisingly also as someone who ‘seemed a typical village-lad, lacking smartness and self-confidence’. Ghosh has no qualms about saying, ‘I did not think very highly of him’ [15] at the time. Durga Bhabhi, who helped plan the nineteen-year-old Bhagat Singh’s escape the night after the Delhi Assembly Bomb in 1928, remembers his clothes as being stained and shredded. She was left to marvel in later years at how he could have risen ‘to shake the British Raj by its roots’. [16] Yet, the worn lungi did not dampen his developing political resolve as Bhagat Singh played out his various acting roles at the National College. It was here also that in 1923, the year he passed his intermediate examinations, that Bhagat Singh joined the Hindustan Republican Association (HRA). This too was not the reason why he failed to stay and